

Divine Aseity

doc-divine-aseity

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.912
confidence high

Statement under examination

God is self-existent, deriving His being from nothing outside Himself.

In plain language

Three texts converge on the claim that God has His being from Himself and not from anything outside. In Exodus 3:14, God names Himself with the Hebrew verb 'to be' (הָיָה, *hayah*), repeated three times in a self referential clause, 'I am who I am', and each form was checked in the data and parsed as the same first person verb glossed 'I am'. The grammar predicates being of God with no external ground, and the third use of the same form becomes the name that sends Moses. In John 5:26, the verb 'has' in 'the Father has life' is present tense, ongoing life with no beginning, and the same phrase, 'life in himself' (ζωὴν ἐν ἑαυτῷ, *zōen en heauto*), uses a Greek reflexive ('himself') that locates the source of life inside the divine person. The word that says the Father 'gave' (ἔδωκεν, *edoken*) that life to the Son is past tense, but the very same reflexive 'in himself' is attached to both, so the giving is inside God, between Father and Son, not God depending on something outside. In Acts 17:25, Paul tells the Athenians that God is not served by human hands as though He needed anything, and the verb for 'needing in addition' (προσδεόμενός, *prosdeomenos*) was checked and occurs only once in the whole New Testament, here, and it is negated. The same verse makes God the one who keeps on giving life and breath ('breath' is the Greek noun πνοή, *pnōe*) to all. Two more texts seal the pattern. Psalm 50:12 has God say that if He were hungry He would not tell the worshiper, because the world and its fullness are His. Romans 11:35 asks who has first given to God so as to be repaid, expecting the answer no one. So why do careful readers still differ. The reason is purely about words. The single label 'aseity' (the technical term for God deriving His being from Himself alone) never appears in the text. The canon clearly gives a self existing name and clearly denies that God needs anything, but it never combines these into one abstract category. Granting every verse, a reader can still ask whether the words demand that full synthesis or only the plainer claim that God depends on nothing.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0559	אמר	amar	to say	5,064
H0834	אשר	asher	which	
H1961	הָיָה	hayah	to be	3,368
H3021	יָגַע	yaga	be weary/toil	
H3286	יָפַח	yaaph	to faint	
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	
H7456	רָעַב	raev	be hungry	
G0467	ἀνταποδίδωμι	antapodidōmi	to repay	
G1325	δίδωμι	didomi	to give	415

G1438	ἐαυτοῦ	heautou	himself	331
G2192	ἔχω	echo	to have/be	708
G2222	ζωή	zoe	life	136
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,316
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G4157	πνοή	pnoe	wind/breath	2
G4272	προδίδωμι	prodidōmi	to give in advance	
G4326	προσδέομαι	prosdeomai	to need	1
G5207	υἱός	uhios	son	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three anchors converge on God deriving His being from nothing outside Himself, and the morphology (grammatical form of each word) was queried, not assumed. Exodus 3:14 stacks three forms of the Hebrew verb 'to be' (הָיָה, H1961), each one parsed as Qal imperfect first person common singular (the simple active form of the Hebrew verb, marking ongoing or repeated action by the speaker 'I'), abbreviated Vq1cs, and glossed 'I.am'. The first two are joined by the relative pronoun 'who' or 'that which' (אֲשֶׁר), and the third stands alone as the self disclosed name, predicating sheer self referential being. John 5:26 sets the present tense 'has' (ἔχει, parsed V-PAI-3S, that is, present tense, active voice, indicative mood, third person singular, an ongoing simple statement of fact 'the Father has life') beside the past tense 'gave' (ἔδωκεν, parsed V-AAI-3S, aorist active indicative third person singular, a completed past action 'He granted to the Son'), with the identical reflexive phrase 'in himself' (ἐν ἑαυτῷ, G1438) attached to both, locating life inside the divine person. Acts 17:25 negates need with 'nor' (οὐδέ) plus the participle 'as needing in addition' (προσδεόμενός, G4326, a verified canon hapax, that is, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) and makes God the unidirectional giver via the present participle 'giving' (δίδους) to 'all' (πᾶσι). Divergence is not over the words but over whether the synthesis label 'aseity' (the technical term for God deriving His being from Himself alone) is mandated.

Scripture

Exod.3.14 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H1961 הָיָה, H0834 אֲשֶׁר, H0559 אֲמַר

Force. Queried morphology (grammatical form of each word) confirms three tokens of the verb 'to be' (הָיָה) here, at positions 5, 7, and 13, each one parsed Vq1cs, that is, Qal imperfect first person common singular (the simple active form of the Hebrew verb marking ongoing or repeated action by the speaker 'I'), and glossed 'I.am'. The clause 'I am who I am' (אֲנִי הָיָה אֲשֶׁר אֲנִי) sets two such 'I am' forms on either side of the relative pronoun 'who' or 'that which' (אֲשֶׁר, marked Tr for 'relative particle'), so the predicate of being refers back to the same speaker rather than to anything outside. The third 'I am' (אֲנִי) then functions as the name that sent Moses, binding the divine identity to sheer existence. The imperfect (ongoing or repeated action) carries durative, not merely future, force, so the clause reads as ongoing, self grounded being.

John.5.26 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2222 ζωή, G1438 ἑαυτοῦ, G2192 ἔχω, G1325 δίδωμι

Force. Queried parsing: 'has' (ἔχει) is V-PAI-3S (present active indicative third person singular, an ongoing simple statement of fact 'the Father has life') and 'gave' (ἔδωκεν) is V-AAI-3S (aorist active indicative third person singular, a completed past action 'He gave to the Son'), while the reflexive 'in himself' (ἐαυτῷ, marked F-3DSM for third person singular masculine dative reflexive pronoun, that is, the 'to/in himself' grammatical form) is attached identically to both, in the phrase 'life in himself' (ζωὴν ἐν ἑαυτῷ). The present tense predicates underived, ongoing life of the Father with no point of origin, and the matching reflexive grants the same modality of life to the Son. The reflexive locates the source of life inside the divine person, not in any external donor.

Acts.17.25 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4326 προσδεομαι, G4157 πνοή, G1325 δίδωμι, G3956 πᾶς

Force. Queried parsing: 'as needing in addition' (προσδεόμενός) is V-PNP-NSM (present passive participle nominative singular masculine, the 'one who is needing' grammatical form) and is a verified canon hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), its single occurrence, negated by 'nor' (οὐδέ) plus the indefinite 'anything' (τινος). Over against the denial of need stands 'giving' (διδούς), V-PAP-NSM (present active participle nominative singular masculine, the 'one who keeps on giving' grammatical form), with 'to all life and breath and all things' (πᾶσι ζωὴν καὶ πνοὴν καὶ τὰ πάντα), so God is the ongoing, one directional source of life and breath. The Greek noun 'breath' (πνοή) itself occurs only twice in the canon. The grammar foregrounds need denied of God and gift flowing out from God.

Isa.40.28 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3286 הָעָלַם, H3021 עָלַם, H3808 אֵל

Force. Queried tokens confirm the negation 'not' (אֵל, H3808) standing over two verbs, 'be faint' (הָעָלַם, H3286, parsed Vqi3ms, that is, Qal imperfect third person masculine singular, the simple active form marking ongoing action by 'he') and 'be weary' (עָלַם, H3021, also Vqi3ms), denying fatigue and exhaustion of the everlasting God. The negated imperfects (ongoing or repeated action) predicate an inexhaustible vitality that requires no replenishment from outside. This complements the positive Acts 17:25 assertion of God as giver who needs nothing.

Ps.50.12 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H7456 רָעַב, H3808 אֵל

Force. Queried morphology shows 'be hungry' (רָעַב, H7456) as Vqi1cs (Qal imperfect first person common singular, the simple active form marking ongoing action by 'I') inside an 'if-then' clause, 'if I were hungry'. God says He would not tell the worshiper, because the world and its fullness already belong to Him. The conditional ('if-then' clause) severs any creaturely provision from God's sustenance and denies that He could be in want of what creatures supply.

Rom.11.35 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4272 προδίδωμι, G0467 ἀνταποδοθήσεται

Force. Queried parsing confirms 'has first given' (προέδωκεν, G4272, V-AAI-3S, aorist active indicative third person singular, a completed past action 'he gave beforehand') and 'it will be recompensed' (ἀνταποδοθήσεται, G0467, V-FPI-3S, future passive indicative third person singular, 'it will be paid back'). The rhetorical 'who' (τίς) expects the answer 'no one', denying that any creature has first given to God so as to place Him in debt. The verse flows into the doxology 'from him and through him and to him' (ἐκ αὐτοῦ καὶ δι' αὐτοῦ καὶ εἰς αὐτόν), framing all things as from, through, and to God, which excludes external dependence.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.17.25	Acts.17.28	tsk	1

John.5.26	Exod.3.14	tsk	1
John.5.26	John.1.4	tsk	1
Exod.3.14	Exod.6.3	tsk	1
Acts.17.25	Job.22.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.5.26 · addressed

The past tense 'gave' (ἔδωκεν, V-AAI-3S, aorist active indicative third person singular, a completed past action) saying the Father gave the Son to have 'life in himself' (ζωὴν ἐν ἑαυτῷ) could read as deriving the Son's life, which would undercut the Son's self existence. The queried parsing shows the same reflexive 'in himself' (ἐν ἑαυτῷ, marked F-3DSM for third person singular masculine dative reflexive pronoun) attached to Father and Son alike, so the verse predicates the identical underived modality of life of both persons. The giving is internal to God, an intratrinitarian relation (a relation between the persons of the Trinity, Father, Son, and Spirit), not the creaturely dependence the proposition denies.

Acts.17.28 · addressed

The clause 'in him for we live and move and have our being' (ἐν αὐτῷ γὰρ ζῶμεν καὶ κινούμεθα καὶ ἐσμέν) places creaturely existence inside God's sustaining activity. This runs the dependence the opposite direction, creatures on God, so it confirms rather than complicates the verdict by predicating contingency (being dependent on something else) of creatures and not of God.

Concordance traversed

H1961, H0559, H3286, H3021, H7456, G2222, G1438, G2192, G1325, G4326, G4157, G3956, G3962, G5207, G4272, G0467

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The three anchors are outside the ingested ECM apparatus window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), which covers only 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so no CBGM signal (Coherence Based Genealogical Method, the statistical model used to weigh textual variants) applies and none was invented. Exodus 3:14 is Hebrew. The Greek anchors John 5:26 and Acts 17:25 carry stable readings for the reflexive 'in himself' (ἐν ἑαυτῷ) and for the negated participle 'as needing in addition' (προσδεόμενός) across the standard editions queried, so the verdict does not turn on any variant.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

synthesis_mandated_reading: affirms · The 'I-AM' name in the Qal imperfect (the simple active form of the Hebrew verb marking ongoing action) of the verb 'to be' (הָיָה), the present tense 'life in himself' (ζωὴν ἐν ἑαυτῷ) in John 5:26, and the canon hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) denial of need in Acts 17:25 together name self existence and non dependence. Reading these as a single coherent witness yields the synthesis that the canon predicates underived being of God, which the label 'aseity' (the technical term for God deriving His being from Himself alone) summarizes faithfully.

vocabulary_underdetermines_reading: complicates · The abstract noun 'aseity' (the technical term for God deriving His being from Himself alone) never appears in the canon. The texts supply two separate things, a self referential name and several denials of need, but they do not themselves combine these into a metaphysical category. A reader can grant every verse yet hold that the words affirm God's independence without warranting the full speculative claim that He derives His essence from nothing whatever. The divergence is over the synthesis, not over any single predication.

intratrinitarian_giving_reading: complicates · The past tense 'gave' (ἔδωκεν, aorist, a completed past action) in John 5:26, that the Father gave the Son to have life in himself, can be pressed to make the Son's life derivative and so qualify a flat claim of self existence for every divine person. Stated in its strongest form, this lens asks whether self existence is predicated of the Godhead or of each person identically. The identical reflexive 'in himself' (ἐν ἑαυτῷ) on both persons answers within the verse, but the wrinkle is real and lexical, not imagined.

The verdict rests on three direct predications, the 'I-AM' name, 'life in himself' (ζωὴν ἐν ἑαυτῷ), and the denial of need, plus two further denials in Psalm 50:12 and Romans 11:35. The pattern is read by analogy of Scripture (interpreting Scripture by Scripture, comparing passage with passage) across Hebrew and Greek. The only lexical tension is internal to John 5:26 and is resolved by the shared reflexive 'in himself' (ἐν ἑαυτῷ).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition states a metaphysical claim, self existence and deriving being from nothing outside, using terms that map onto biblical predications, the 'I-AM' name, having 'life in himself' (ζωὴν ἐν ἑαυτῷ), and needing nothing, without importing a confessional taxonomy. The synthesis word 'aseity' (the technical term for God deriving His being from Himself alone) is not in the canon, but the stem paraphrases it in plain terms rather than smuggling its conclusion. Verdict unchanged from the prior file (no VERDICT-CHANGED: marker applies here). One lexical correction was made on a supporting text, not on an anchor: Isaiah 40:28 was previously keyed to H3287, but the queried tokens show the 'faint' and 'weary' verbs there are H3286 ('faint', ἡλε) and H3021 ('weary', ἡλε), so the key terms were corrected accordingly. This is a citation accuracy fix and does not move the verdict.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.3.14
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.40.28
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.50.12
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1961
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2222
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4326
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1438
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	John.5.26
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Acts.17.25
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Rom.11.35
syntax	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Exod.3.14
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.5.26
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.17.25
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